

St Paul's Cathedral

Until the late 20th century, St Paul's Cathedral was the tallest building on London's City skyline, designed by its architect, Sir Christopher Wren, to tower over the spires of his other city churches. Its location on Ludgate Hill has been a site of worship for over 1,400 years. Wren's cathedral, completed in 1708, replaced Old St Paul's, destroyed by the Great Fire of 1666. A synthesis of medieval, Gothic, classical and baroque styles, its commanding feature is the dome rising 111 metres (365 ft) to the spire at its summit. Built on a Latin cross plan, St Paul's has a classical portico at each end. Wren was familiar with the unique octagonal lantern tower of Ely Cathedral (where his uncle was bishop), which spans the aisles as well as the central nave. He adapted this for St Paul's dome, which is raised on a tall drum surrounded by pilasters and pierced with windows in groups of three, separated by gilded niches. Echoing St Peter's Basilica in Rome, the dome is double-shelled, with a load-bearing brick core. The west front is based on the eastern façade of the Louvre, designed by Claude Perrault (1613–88).

